

Adaptive communal space in cities



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This paper examines the role of adaptive communal space (ACS) in supporting resilient, adaptable and community-oriented urban development. ACS refers to (semi-) public spaces collectively shaped, managed and used by local communities to respond to evolving local needs. Examples of ACS include community gardens, cultural and creative hubs, or spaces for circular economy initiatives. Drawing on interviews, survey responses and comparative literature, the paper argues that ACS represents a shift from exclusively top-down service delivery towards shared stewardship and local problem-solving. It identifies six areas through which ACS can contribute to better urban outcomes: social connectivity, environmental management and resource efficiency, economic opportunities, cultural activity, temporal adaptability and institutional flexibility. The paper highlights that the effectiveness and continuity of ACS depend less on spatial form than on enabling institutional conditions, including legal certainty, effective governance, financial capacity and policy co-ordination. It concludes with ways forward for policymakers to strengthen local governance capacity, safeguard access to space, support experimentation and encourage adaptive collaboration across sectors and levels of government.

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Executive summary

Cities today face overlapping pressures – from natural hazards and economic precarity to social fragmentation and declining trust in institutions. These challenges expose the limits of conventional urban systems and demand new approaches to how urban space is governed, used and shared. The concept of adaptive communal space (ACS) offers a practical and policy-relevant lens for addressing local priorities while fostering civic initiative and spatial adaptability. It also provides an opportunity for local innovation that can contribute to new forms of economic development and urban regeneration.

ACS refers to (semi-) public spaces managed and shaped by local communities to meet their evolving needs. Examples include community gardens, shared cultural and creative hubs, and circular repair sites. Rather than prescribing a new spatial typology, ACS highlights a shift in institutional logic – from top-down planning to shared creation of public value. By enabling people to participate not only as users, but as co-creators and stewards of their local environment, ACS contributes both to the everyday functioning and long-term resilience of cities.

ACS can activate underused assets, reduce costs and lower barriers to local entrepreneurship by enabling shared use of space, infrastructure and governance capacity. Depending on local conditions and priorities, ACS can contribute to six main areas of public value:

- Social cohesion – strengthening relationships, shared use and trust across communities
- Environmental stewardship and resource efficiency – supporting local environmental management and the efficient use of shared spaces and resources
- Economic opportunities – enabling social enterprise, skill-building and the reuse of resources
- Cultural expression – nurturing local identity, artistic production and heritage
- Temporal adaptability – responding flexibly through seasonal programming and temporary use
- Institutional autonomy – operating within hybrid governance models combining local initiative with enabling institutional frameworks

By focusing on these domains, ACS supports adaptive urban development while enabling economic, social, environmental and institutional transformation. Its contribution to public value depends less on physical form than on the institutional conditions that support its emergence, continuity and evolution – including legal certainty, good governance, financial capacity and policy integration. Recognising and enabling ACS as civic infrastructure can help governments foster more participatory urban futures. Based on findings from interviews, survey responses and comparative literature review, this paper highlights actionable directions for policymakers seeking to use ACS in their communities:

- Support while preserving civic autonomy
- Invest in governance capacity
- Safeguard civic access to space and procedures
- Promote institutional collaboration across sectors and scales
- Reframe evaluation practices through participatory approaches
- Enable experimentation through adaptive and iterative policy frameworks

1 Defining adaptive communal space

This chapter introduces adaptive communal space (ACS) as a policy-relevant lens to understand how communities shape urban space through shared use and collective governance. It defines ACS, grounds it in theoretical traditions and introduces a theory of change to clarify how community-led practices create public value.

Introduction

Cities serve as engines of economic, social, cultural and environmental innovation. They attract investment, talent and creativity. Yet they are under growing pressure from megatrends such as urbanisation, natural hazards and demographic shifts. The COVID-19 pandemic further exposed spatial inequalities and the fragility of local care systems, while underscoring the importance of accessible public space in building civic trust and social resilience. In light of these developments, it is timely to revisit how urban space is governed and experienced. This paper proposes the concept of adaptive communal space (ACS) as a practical, policy-relevant framework to address this challenge. ACS is defined as (semi-) public space managed and shaped by local communities to meet their evolving needs. Examples include community-led greening initiatives, circular repair hubs and shared cultural programming – each embedding civic engagement in concrete, localised practice. It allows communities to play a direct role in shaping cities, generating value across economic, social, environmental and institutional dimensions. ACS provides infrastructure through which civic participation, creativity and trust can take root. Community spaces such as libraries, parks and community centres play a crucial role in resilience and crisis management (Klinenberg, 2018^[1]) and urban commons foster intergenerational connections (OECD, 2025^[2]). At the same time, only 30% of people feel they can influence public decisions, illustrating the need to rethink the relationship between space and governance (OECD, 2024^[3]). Additionally, the OECD highlights the potential for cities to use crises as opportunities for urban renewal and resilience (OECD, 2024^[4]).

Objective, methodology and structure of the paper

This paper aims to enhance the understanding of adaptive communal space (ACS) and provide policymakers with actionable insights to support its development across diverse urban contexts. It pursues three core objectives:

- To articulate the value proposition of ACS as a lever for urban development.
- To propose a working definition and conceptual framework for ACS, grounded in interdisciplinary theory and comparative case analysis.
- To formulate concrete policy recommendations and implementation tools for national and local authorities, building on real-world experiences and institutional practice.

The research combines conceptual analysis with a literature review and place-based evidence to provide a comprehensive understanding of ACS. A total of 21 qualitative interviews and surveys were carried out with urban professionals, policymakers, community organisers and academics across seven cities: Amsterdam, Berlin, Brussels, Istanbul, Ljubljana, Paris and Yokohama, as detailed in Table 1.1. The cities were selected to reflect diverse governance models, legal frameworks and cultural-political contexts in which ACS operates. Four cities – Amsterdam, Berlin, Ljubljana and Yokohama – were analysed in greater depth through case studies.

Table 1.1. List of participating cities

City	Interview	Survey	Workshop
Amsterdam	X	X	X
Berlin	X	X	X
Brussels	X		X
Istanbul	X		
Ljubljana		X	
Paris	X		
Yokohama	X	X	X

In addition to fieldwork, the research incorporates insights from an expert workshop titled “Rethinking space in cities: Unlocking the potential of adaptive communal space (ACS) to connect people, places and firms”, which was hosted by the OECD in February 2025. The workshop helped test preliminary insights, strengthen the typology and explore the national relevance of the proposed policy tools.

The paper is structured as follows:

- Chapter 1 defines the concept of adaptive communal space (ACS), grounds it in interdisciplinary theory and introduces both a theory of change and a typology of five governance models. It highlights the distinct institutional logic of community-led and hybrid forms and frames ACS as a civic infrastructure capable of generating public value across economic, social, environmental and institutional dimensions.
- Chapter 2 explores how ACS emerges and evolves in practice through four case studies: Amsterdam, Berlin, Ljubljana and Yokohama. These cases highlight how enabling conditions such as legal recognition, financial continuity and co-governance arrangements interact to shape diverse ACS approaches. The chapter also tests the conceptual framework introduced in Chapter 1, drawing out strategic lessons on governance, legal enablers and the balance between autonomy and recognition.
- Chapter 3 identifies the institutional requirements for supporting ACS at scale across four domains of public action: legal frameworks, governance, finance and policy integration. It proposes a multidimensional evaluation framework based on six public value domains and offers concrete policy tools – including a Checklist for Public Action – to embed ACS into long-term urban strategies.

Foundations of ACS

Theory of change

To understand how adaptive communal space (ACS) can contribute structurally to more, participatory cities, it is essential to clarify the mechanisms through which local initiatives generate public value. While ACS often begins as a situated, small-scale practice, its societal impact extends beyond the immediate use of space. It can catalyse new forms of co-operation, stewardship and care, especially when such approaches are embedded in enabling environments. ACS can activate underused assets, reduce costs and lower barriers to local entrepreneurship by enabling shared use of space, infrastructure and governance capacity.

The theory of change presented below serves to articulate this process. It outlines how different types of input – such as community leadership, access to underused space and legal flexibility – can trigger a chain of activities that lead to broader outcomes. By making these dynamics explicit, the framework supports both policymakers and community actors in identifying where intervention is most needed to unlock the full potential of ACS.

Table 1.2 summarises the key components of this logic and illustrates how ACS evolves over time – from informal experimentation to embedded infrastructure – and underlines the importance of aligning short-term actions with long-term transformation.

Table 1.2. Key components of value creation through a theory of change

Input	Activities	Output	Outcome	Impact
Availability of underutilised or transformable urban space	Community-driven spatial design and use	Establishment of a functioning ACS with basic infrastructure (e.g. 1 kitchen, 1 greenhouse, 1 incubator)	Stronger collaboration between local actors, emergence of new governance practices	More adaptive urban development
Local initiative and community leadership	Governance experiments (e.g. co-operatives)	Creation of co-governance models or civic associations	Increased local ownership, leadership and empowerment	Greater social cohesion and civic trust
Openness and legal flexibility of the municipality	Mixed-use programmes (e.g. food, care, education, arts)	Programming of local stakeholders and networks	Emergence of community-based services and new social, economic or environmental practices	Resilient urban systems with decentralised support capacity
Seed capital for economic, social, cultural and/or environmental experiments	Knowledge sharing and exchange	Number of workshops, cultural programmes or community activities	Improved economic, environmental, cultural and/or social practices at community level	Improved economic opportunity, well-being and life satisfaction in neighbourhoods
Policy support for economic, social, cultural and/or environmental innovation	Involvement with municipal institutions and frameworks	ACS integrated in neighborhood plans	Improved institutional innovations, strengthened cross-sector collaboration and policy coherence	Structural recognition of ACS as a lever for sustainable urban transformation

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

The evolution of ACS also brings with it a structural tension: as community-led spaces gain recognition and institutional support, they may risk losing the very autonomy and adaptive capacity that enabled them to flourish. This paradox – where success can invite co-option or displacement – underscores the importance of designing enabling frameworks that protect not just the existence of ACS, but also their civic character.

Strategic alignment with broader policy agendas

ACS contributes to key dimensions of the OECD Well-being Framework, notably social connections, civic engagement and environmental quality (OECD, 2020^[5]). In addition, the social and solidarity economy (SSE) offers a valuable institutional reference point, emphasising community benefit, democratic governance and hybrid economic models (OECD, 2023^[6]; European Commission, 2021^[7]). A social enterprise is an entity, which trades goods and services, that fulfils a societal objective and whose main purpose is not the maximisation of profit for the owners but its reinvestment for the continued attainment of its societal goals (OECD, 2022^[8]). This definition resonates with many ACS initiatives, particularly those that operate at the intersection of economic resilience and community empowerment.

ACS supports widely recognised urban policy objectives, including long-term liveability, local resilience and cross-sector collaboration, as reflected in a range of national and city-level policy frameworks. However, the practical realisation of ACS varies considerably in terms of form, initiating actors and levels of community engagement. To clarify this diversity, the following chapter presents a typology of five ACS models. This typology offers a systematic structure for evaluating how different ACS variants translate strategic objectives – such as trust-building, co-governance and spatial transformation – into context-specific urban practice. It also provides the basis for understanding the alignment between conceptual goals and real-world dynamics, as further explored in the empirical case studies in Chapter 2.

Theoretical foundations of ACS

The concept of ACS, as developed in this paper, draws on the theoretical perspectives of Henri Lefebvre and Elinor Ostrom to frame its spatial and institutional dynamics.

Lefebvre's critique of top-down planning highlights the need for spaces shaped through social relations, aligning closely with ACS's adaptability and community involvement. Lefebvre argued that space is not a passive backdrop but is actively produced – lived, contested and negotiated – through everyday practices (Lefebvre, 1996^[9]). His rhythm analysis framework conceptualises cities as dynamic interactions between human activities and spatial structures, reinforcing the importance of adaptable, community-centred spaces (Adhitya, 2017^[10]). Lefebvre's theory affirms the value of community-centred, flexible spaces that evolve through collective interaction and changing needs.

Ostrom's work on common-pool resources underscores the importance of community governance, a key feature of ACS. Ostrom demonstrated that communities can manage shared resources effectively without relying solely on state or market mechanisms. Her research showed that under the right conditions, communities can design governance rules, resolve conflicts and sustain shared assets over time (Ostrom, 1990^[11]). These insights are foundational to ACS, particularly in recognising community stewardship as both feasible and adaptive compared to traditional top-down governance models.

Together, Lefebvre and Ostrom provide a compelling theoretical basis for ACS as a model for community-driven governance. ACS extends their theories by focusing on the dynamic and adaptive nature of communal spaces, offering an innovative model for urban space that empowers communities to manage and redefine their environment in response to evolving urban challenges.

Five types of ACS

To fully understand how adaptive communal space (ACS) functions, it is critical to contextualise each space within its unique urban setting. As Foucault argues, space is not neutral; it is produced through the interplay of power, social relations and political structures (Foucault, 1977^[12]). By contextualising ACS, we can better understand how different governance models emerge based on local needs and societal values, as well as the tensions that might arise when these spaces interact with broader urban policies.

Building on the earlier definition, ACS assumes a minimum threshold of community agency: the ability to organise, co-govern and adapt the space over time. From this assumption, five governance models are distinguished (Table 1.3), each reflecting a specific configuration of civic initiative and institutional involvement.

This typology of ACS is designed to clarify the different ways in which ACS can take shape across urban contexts, linking each model to broader societal outcomes. While ACS shares key characteristics with established theories of urban space (Lefebvre, 1992^[13]) and commons governance (Ostrom, 1990^[11]), the five-model typology developed here offers a novel framework for policy and practice. It reflects the central dimensions of community agency and institutional engagement, distinguishing between diverse governance forms, from state-led to community-led.

All typologies, tables and figures presented in this section have been subject to expert feedback, including interviews, surveys and discussions held during an OECD workshop. These insights have been integral to both the conceptual framing and the empirical differentiation of the five ACS models.

Table 1.3. Five models of ACS

ACS model	Governance	Funding	Benefits	Limitations	Example
1. State-led public spaces	Municipal government	Public funding	Accessibility for all citizens, formal public services	Bureaucratic rigidity, limited direct community involvement	Park, library, museum, community centre
2. Privately managed public spaces (PMPs)	Corporate or private ownership	Commercially funded through real estate returns and rental income	High-quality infrastructure, security and maintenance	Limited public access, prioritisation of profit over social goals	Granary Square (London)
3. Profit-driven mixed-use developments	Private developers, real estate firms	Private capital, real estate investments, public-private partnerships (PPP)	Urban efficiency, economic diversification, increased amenities	Prioritisation of profit over social goals	High Line (New York), Mercato Metropolitano (Milan)
4. Social & cultural hubs (semi/non-profit)	Non-profits, social enterprises, co-operatives	Cultural & social grants and subsidies, co-operative capital	Community-driven creative and cultural initiatives, including economic functions	Financial instability, reliance on subsidies and temporary permits	Shibaura House (Tokio), Müze Gazhane (Istanbul)
5. Community-led ACS (non-profit)	Co-operative, participatory governance, self-management	Public funds, crowdfunding, co-operative capital	Flexible, long-term, sustainable, participatory functions	Financial instability, complex governance, dependent on volunteers	Haus der Statistik (Berlin), Green Field (Amsterdam)

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

1. State-led public spaces

State-led public spaces are developed, maintained and governed by public authorities – typically municipal governments. They include libraries, parks and community centres that provide universal access and institutional continuity. While the mandate is to be open to all, these spaces tend to operate through hierarchical governance structures that may limit direct community participation. However, when complemented by participatory programming and open-use provisions, they can form a stable backbone of civic infrastructure that supports learning, well-being and access to services.

2. Privately managed public spaces (PMPs)

Privately managed public spaces are maintained by private actors – often developers or property consortia – and made accessible to the public under negotiated terms. These spaces may offer high-quality amenities and safety, but their governance and access conditions are typically defined by commercial logic. As such, they may restrict civic agency, prioritise profit over access and blur the boundary between public and private interests. Embedding community rights, co-use mechanisms and transparent rules of access may help align such spaces with public value outcomes.

3. Mixed-use developments (profit-driven)

These spaces are embedded in commercial real estate developments that integrate public-facing functions – such as retail, leisure or temporary markets – within wider urban regeneration schemes. Funded primarily through private investment and often structured through public-private partnerships (PPPs), they can contribute to economic diversification and spatial vibrancy. Yet, unless community needs are deliberately

incorporated, these developments may miss opportunities to create greater social value. Without safeguards, they risk reinforcing spatial inequality.

4. Social and cultural hubs (semi-/non-profit)

Social and cultural hubs are governed by non-profits, foundations or co-operatives and rely on a mix of grant funding, co-operative capital and in-kind contributions. These spaces foster artistic production, social connection and local experimentation. They often function as anchor points in community life, blending cultural programming with access to quality services. Creative hubs within urban commons play a crucial role in the dynamics of creative cities and stimulate the local economy (Cohendet, Grandadam and Simon, 2010^[14]). As such, they exemplify how ACS can act as catalysts for urban innovation, supporting both civic resilience and economic opportunity.

5. Community-led ACS (non-profit)

Community-led ACS are initiated and governed by local actors through collective ownership, volunteer engagement and grassroots decision making. These spaces are deeply embedded in place-based needs and typically operate in informal or temporary conditions. They are agile and can drive long-term social impact through mutual care, environmental stewardship and civic organising. However, without structural support, they remain vulnerable in the longer term. Public authorities can strengthen these models through enabling frameworks, flexible tenure instruments and investment in organisational capacity – while protecting the autonomy that underpins their value. A “Do It Yourself” (DIY) culture plays a major role in many community-led ACS. This is exemplified by the Experimental Living-Working Community (ELWC) at The Green Field in Amsterdam, discussed in Chapter 4, where self-sufficiency, collective craftsmanship and circular economy principles are central (van Altena Advies, 2021^[15]). Through reuse, upcycling and shared maintenance, ACS can contribute to more sustainable and self-organising urban infrastructure.

These models form a continuum of civic agency and institutional engagement. The following section examines how they generate different types of public value, depending on their governance configuration and degree of adaptability.

Institutional logic and mediating function

ACS can function as a mediating infrastructure that connects formal institutions with informal civic practices. Each governance model in the typology is shaped by its underlying institutional logic, which reflects both theoretical foundations – such as Lefebvre’s notion of socially produced space and Ostrom’s principles of commons governance – and empirical insights from comparative case studies. These institutional logics determine how decisions are made, how community engagement is structured and how public value is generated.

This institutional logic directly shapes how each model contributes to the outcomes highlighted in the theory of change. For example, models with higher community agency – such as community-led (non-profit) models – align strongly with community resilience. In contrast, state-led models typically prioritise stability and policy continuity, although some evolve into hybrid models that combine public oversight with civic-driven innovation. These hybrid models foster institutional experimentation and collaborative governance, making them particularly relevant in addressing contemporary urban challenges.

Table 1.4 synthesises the key public value domains in ACS, as shaped by their distinct institutional logics and governance configurations. Throughout this paper, these six outcome areas are referred to as public value domains.

Table 1.4. Contributions of ACS models to public value domains

Core aspect	Contribution	Institutional logic
Social cohesion & trust	Fosters collective use, trust and collaboration among local actors.	Participatory governance and shared responsibility.
Environmental stewardship and resource efficiency	Supports local environmental management and the efficient use of shared space and resources.	Shared responsibility for the management of space and resources.
Economic opportunities	Provides platforms for local and social enterprises, skill development and the reuse of underused assets.	Local, adaptive and mixed-form economic arrangements.
Cultural expression	Encourages grassroots programming and artistic experimentation.	Multifunctionality and cultural integration.
Temporal adaptability	Spaces are activated seasonally or episodically to respond to changing needs.	Flexible governance arrangements.
Institutional autonomy	Operates within hybrid governance models combining local initiative with enabling institutional frameworks.	Hybrid governance balancing autonomy and institutional support.

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

By focusing on these domains, ACS serves as a vital dimension of adaptive urban development, supporting social, economic, environmental and institutional change in a context-specific manner. These value domains are interrelated and their impact is most effectively realised when ACS is supported by the enabling conditions discussed in Chapter 3. This multifaceted approach ensures that ACS is not just a temporary or marginal phenomenon, but a foundational layer of urban governance.

The differences in public value creation across the five ACS models stem from their underlying institutional logics – particularly the degree of civic agency, the governance structure and the capacity to respond to local needs. Table 1.5 operationalises these dynamics by linking each model's governance characteristics to its expected contributions, building on the typology introduced earlier.

Table 1.5. ACS models and their capacity to generate public value

Public value domain/ ACS model	Social cohesion & trust	Environmental stewardship and resource efficiency	Economic opportunities	Cultural expression	Temporal adaptability	Institutional autonomy
State-led (semi) public space	medium	low	medium	medium	low	medium
Privately led public space	medium	low	medium	medium	low	low
Mixed-use (profit-driven)	medium	medium	medium	medium	medium	medium
Social & cultural hubs (semi/non-profit)	high	medium	high	high	high	high
Community-led (non-profit)	high	high	high	high	high	high

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

Conclusion

Chapter 1 provides a diagnostic lens for assessing ACS, notably in terms of institutions and areas of public value creation. It shows that ACS is not merely a spatial form but a strategic layer of adaptive urban governance, connecting social, economic, environmental and institutional agendas while opening room for civic experimentation. These diagnostic insights set the stage for Chapter 2, where four international case studies test the framework in practice.

2 ACS in practice: Case studies

This chapter explores how adaptive communal space (ACS) materialises in diverse urban contexts. Through four case studies in Amsterdam, Berlin, Ljubljana and Yokohama, it examines how ACS is initiated, maintained and transformed through civic initiative, spatial opportunity and institutional openness. Each case is analysed along: (i) the trajectory of development, (ii) the governance arrangements, and (iii) the strategic relevance for urban policy.

Introduction

While Chapter 1 outlined the conceptual foundations of adaptive communal space (ACS), this chapter explores how ACS evolves in practice. Each case illustrates a distinct pathway – from informal activation to embedded co-governance – shaped by local needs, spatial opportunity and degrees of institutional support. Rather than following fixed models, ACS emerges through context-specific dynamics that blend civic initiative with public responsibility. The case studies demonstrate how these configurations affect continuity, trust and social value. Together, they suggest that enabling ACS depends not only on recognition, but on flexible frameworks that support civic agency.

Case studies

Amsterdam: The Green Field as ACS in transition

Trajectory and transition

The Green Field originated as a community-led initiative to reclaim a former sewage site in Amsterdam-Noord, activated in 2021 by the association De Verademing – a coalition of artists, residents and environmental groups. Its “3 Summers” programme introduced seasonal activities in culture, education and agriculture. Initially operating in a vacuum of formal planning, the project gradually became entangled with municipal ambitions for urban transformation, as reflected in policy documents like the Environmental Vision 2050 and Expedition Free Space. This alignment has not led yet to formal institutionalisation but illustrates the transition from civic improvisation toward policy resonance.

Hybrid governance and enabling conditions

While De Verademing acts as the steward of the site, the governance model remains informal and flexible, without long-term legal agreements. This allows adaptability but introduces precarity. Funding is patchworked from municipal grants, grassroots donations and volunteer labour. The municipality states that it embraces the project as emblematic of community innovation, but this support has yet to yield structural backing. Still, the Green Field demonstrates resilience through strong place-based networks and low-threshold, circular infrastructure. It operates in a legal grey zone that enables experimentation but hampers long-term viability.

Strategic insights for policy

The Green Field exemplifies how temporary ACS can act as low-risk urban laboratories. Rather than pushing for full formalisation, cities could offer recognition mechanisms – such as time-bound legal exceptions or low-threshold permits – that protect the adaptive ethos. The case challenges the dichotomy between temporary use and structural infrastructure by showing that temporality itself can generate durable public value. However, policy frameworks may need to evolve to accommodate such civic temporality without absorbing it into rigid planning logics.

Berlin: Haus der Statistik and the power of co-governance

Trajectory and transition

Haus der Statistik began in 2015 when a coalition of civil society actors – including artists, urban planners and activists – launched a campaign to reclaim a vacant German Democratic Republic-era office complex in central Berlin. Under the banner “A city for all”, their action triggered the formation of a public-civic

consortium that gained formal endorsement from the Berlin Senate. The site was transformed into a multifunctional hub for culture, education, housing and civic activities. Its evolution from abandonment to anchor institution illustrates how collective action can initiate systemic change within urban governance.

Hybrid governance and enabling conditions

The governance of *Haus der Statistik* is codified in the *Kooperationsmodell*, a co-governance agreement between five equal partners, including city departments and civic organisations. This legally binding co-operation contract ensures shared decision making and long-term planning. Funding combines public investment, co-operative capital and philanthropic contributions. The structure enables continuity while preserving civic agency. Participatory mechanisms such as co-design workshops and interim uses have reinforced trust, showing how legally grounded hybrid models can enhance flexibility.

Strategic insights for policy

Haus der Statistik demonstrates that co-governance models can be institutionalised without losing democratic vitality. It exemplifies how cities can move beyond consultation toward shared responsibility. Importantly, it shows that national and local policy can support civic-public consortia through legal and financial scaffolding. While not universally replicable, the case illustrates a transferable principle: durable civic infrastructure depends on codified rights to co-create, not merely permissions to participate.

Yokohama: Koganecho's transition from policy to practice

Trajectory and transition

Koganecho, a district in Yokohama, had long been associated with prostitution and criminal activity. This reputation contributed to social stigma, economic decline and neglect from formal planning authorities prior to its cultural regeneration in the early 2000s by the municipal government. Initially led top-down, the intervention aimed to revitalise the area through arts programming and public space renewal. Over time, this shifted into a more community-anchored approach through the Koganecho Area Management Centre (KAMC), a local non-profit that gradually assumed a stewardship role. This evolution reflects a strategic transition from state-led placemaking to embedded governance of cultural activities.

Hybrid governance and enabling conditions

Today, KAMC co-ordinates activities with artists, residents and municipal actors. While land remains publicly owned, its management is delegated, allowing for a mix of control and autonomy. Funding stems from municipal grants, cultural foundations and self-generated income via festivals and exhibitions. Governance is layered, with formal oversight complemented by relational practices of co-creation, including artist residences embedded in the neighbourhood, collaborative festivals, workshops, community learning programmes and other initiatives. Cultural programming has been key in rebuilding trust and reconfiguring the area's public image, transforming stigma into civic pride.

Strategic insights for policy

Koganecho offers a replicable pathway for cities seeking to use cultural infrastructure as a gateway to community agency and economic revitalisation. It shows how participatory arts can do more than decorate urban space – they can rewire relationships between citizens and institutions. Policy should recognise culture not as an afterthought but as foundational infrastructure, particularly in areas of social fragmentation. The case underscores the value of delegated management and the need for funding models that blend public support with local entrepreneurship.

Ljubljana: Metelkova and the autonomy paradox

Trajectory and transition

Metelkova emerged in 1993 when activists squatted a former military site in central Ljubljana, transforming it into a self-managed cultural complex. Born out of resistance to privatisation of urban space and mainstream cultural policy, it has since become a symbol of autonomy, hosting studios, clubs, galleries and social centres. Unlike other ACS cases, *Metelkova*'s trajectory did not involve integration into formal planning systems, maintaining its identity through informal continuity and symbolic capital.

Hybrid governance and enabling conditions

Governance at *Metelkova* is deliberately informal, based on horizontal structures and collective self-management. It receives no formal recognition and yet it operates in a tolerated grey zone. Sustained through volunteer labour and self-financing via events, its resilience lies in its embeddedness in the cultural life of the city. It provides a safe space for alternative forms of cultural expression, precisely because it escapes bureaucratic capture.

Strategic insights for policy

Metelkova challenges the assumption that all civic initiatives should aim for formalisation. It highlights the importance of tolerated autonomy, a condition where informal practices are not absorbed by the state yet are allowed to persist. For policymakers, the lesson is not to institutionalise all ACS, but to protect legal and symbolic space for autonomy to thrive. Cultural value can be sustained without formal governance, provided there is political tolerance and public resonance.

3

Enabling, evaluating and supporting ACS

ACS thrives when legal, financial and policy systems recognise and enable its adaptive nature. This chapter builds on the theory of change to identify institutional conditions for success and proposes tools to evaluate impact across social, economic, environmental and institutional dimensions. It concludes with actionable strategies to support ACS as a structural feature of participatory urban governance.

Introduction

Adaptive communal space (ACS) does not emerge or endure in isolation. Its development relies on an enabling institutional environment – one that recognises its civic and spatial value, supports its unique governance dynamics and promotes long-term continuity through legal, financial and organisational tools.

Earlier in the paper, six key public value domains were introduced (see Table 1.4) to distinguish how different ACS models contribute to adaptive cities. This chapter builds on those domains and translates them into concrete strategies for governments to enable, evaluate and support ACS in practice.

The chapter has three parts:

1. It outlines key enablers across four domains of public action: legal frameworks, governance arrangements, financial infrastructure and policy integration.
2. It then presents an evaluation framework to help policymakers assess the impact of ACS across the six public value domains (Table 3.1).
3. Finally, it proposes a Checklist for Public Action (Figure 3.1), based on the Engage-Plan-Lead approach used in other OECD work on urban development, to guide long-term institutional support for ACS.

By linking public value domains to actionable tools, this chapter moves from conceptual framing toward implementation and offers governments a roadmap to integrate ACS into the everyday governance of cities.

Enabling ACS

Legal and regulatory frameworks

A first enabling condition concerns the legal status of ACS. Many initiatives operate in juridical grey zones, relying on temporary permits, informal agreements or one-off exemptions. While this legal ambiguity allows for creative experimentation, it often inhibits long-term investment, continuity and planning.

Municipalities can play a key role by adapting existing instruments – such as land-use planning frameworks, temporary use provisions or flexible lease contracts – to formally recognise community-led spaces. One frequently cited example is Berlin’s “Interim Use” (*Zwischennutzung*) policy, which enables the interim use of vacant land or buildings under clear legal conditions. Rather than requiring full formalisation, this approach acknowledges that short-term, civic-led use can deliver public value while more permanent arrangements are still under negotiation.

The key challenge lies not in legalising ACS as such, but in doing so without impeding their dynamic and adaptive nature. Legal recognition must avoid imposing rigid structures that undermine what makes ACS effective in the first place – namely, their ability to evolve and respond to local needs and remain open to experimentation. The aim is to offer legal protection and continuity while safeguarding the flexibility that allows ACS to function as living civic infrastructure.

Governance and co-decision making

A second institutional dimension lies in governance. Across the case studies, the transformative potential of ACS strongly correlates with the extent to which communities are actively involved in decision making. Effective models do not treat citizen participation as merely consultative or symbolic, but instead embed community actors within formal co-governance arrangements. Effective community development can emerge when local knowledge and priorities take precedence over institutional assumptions, enabling

communities to shape their environments in ways that enhance participation and resilience (Russel, 2022^[16]).

In Berlin, for example, the “Co-operation contract” (*Kooperationsvertrag*) at *Haus der Statistik* serves as a legally binding governance model in which public authorities and civic organisations jointly share responsibility. This agreement formalises the collaboration between five equal partners – including municipal agencies, housing co-operatives and cultural associations – and outlines how decisions are made regarding programming, development and use of the space. It ensures that civic stakeholders have a recognised and institutionalised role in long-term planning. Similarly, in Yokohama, the Koganecho Area Management Center (KAMC) provides an operational structure for co-ordination between residents, artists and local government. It enables the ongoing co-production of public value, anchored in local knowledge and civic initiative.

The real test of governance is whether community members have a seat at the table when key decisions are made – not just during early activation, but throughout the lifespan of the project. Ensuring that a broad range of perspectives is represented in decision making processes enhances policy effectiveness and civic trust (OECD, 2022^[17]). This highlights the importance of legal and organisational vehicles – such as co-management boards, participatory councils or framework agreements – that provide structure without displacing grassroots agency. When these mechanisms are in place, ACS can function as models of democratic innovation within urban governance. To scale ACS governance successfully, a balance between institutional support and grassroots autonomy is needed. While excessive bureaucracy can hinder the flexibility of initiatives within the social and solidarity economy (SSE), institutional partnerships provide essential resources such as technical support, funding and policy legitimacy (OECD, 2024^[18]).

Financial infrastructure and organisational capacity

Finance is often the most persistent constraint for ACS. Most initiatives begin with minimal resources, relying on voluntary labour, crowdfunding or one-off project grants. While this grassroots energy can foster creativity and commitment, it also creates structural vulnerabilities ranging from burnout of those engaged and fragmentation to dependency on short-term or conditional funding.

Public authorities have a key role to play in strengthening the financial and organisational resilience of ACS. This includes offering multi-year funding schemes that reduce administrative burden, introducing match-funding arrangements to stimulate local co-investment and supporting the development of internal governance structures and professional capacity. Financial resilience is another key aspect. Diversifying funding sources through co-operative revenue models, impact investing or public-private partnerships can reduce dependency on temporary subsidies or donations (Howaldt et al., 2018^[19]).

In the case of Koganecho, financial support was instrumental to its continuity. Municipal funding was combined with consistent co-ordination through the Area Management Centre, enabling a balance between professionalisation and community involvement. Many civic spaces are not short on ideas or commitment – they are short on time, stability and structural funding that allows for long-term continuity.

This underscores that financial sustainability depends not only on access to money, but also on organisational learning, trust-building and the presence of durable frameworks that reduce precarity. Support for core operations, training and governance mentoring is often just as crucial as direct funding for programming or construction. When such investments are made strategically, they enable ACS to evolve from fragile experiments into lasting, value-generating infrastructure.

Policy integration and strategic alignment

ACS are inherently cross-sectoral. They operate at the intersection of many policy areas such as culture, environment, housing, economic renewal and civic participation, yet often fall outside standard administrative categories. This fragmentation leads to blind spots in regulation and missed opportunities for policy synergy.

Governments can take proactive steps to integrate ACS into strategic urban agendas. This might include forming interdepartmental task forces, designating spatial experimentation zones or embedding ACS indicators in well-being dashboards, and circular economy strategies.

In Amsterdam, Expedition Free Space (*Expeditie Vrije Ruimte*) is a government programme initiated by the City of Amsterdam to encourage experimentation in underused urban areas. Alongside this, the city's Environmental Vision 2050 recognises grassroots initiatives as vital to the environmental and social transition. As Nevejan et al. emphasise, alignment between grassroots experimentation and institutional frameworks requires legitimacy, flexibility and continuity (Nevejan et al., 2024^[20]).

Measuring and evaluating ACS impact

Measuring the impact of ACS requires a multidimensional and context-sensitive approach. While a robust evidence base – grounded in quantitative indicators – remains essential to demonstrate value to institutional funders and align with broader urban policy agendas, conventional metrics often fail to capture the full societal, economic, environmental and cultural contributions of ACS. These include less tangible but vital dimensions such as trust, creativity and civic belonging.

Recent OECD work, including *Society at a Glance* (OECD, 2024^[21]) and *How's Life? 2020: Measuring Well-Being* (OECD, 2020^[5]), provides useful frameworks to evaluate these dimensions. The OECD Regional Well-Being Framework and the Better Life Index offer territorialised indicators across domains relevant to ACS such as civic engagement, access to services and environmental quality. These frameworks also emphasise that social cohesion, trust and civic engagement are best understood through a mix of standard metrics and qualitative insights, such as community narratives and testimonials.

However, to reflect the lived reality and adaptive nature of ACS, quantitative approaches must be complemented by participatory evaluation methods. Tools such as community-defined indicators, storytelling, collective mapping and narrative-based assessment help surface the layered and place-based logic of value creation. As argued by Nevejan et al., the evaluation of civic infrastructure requires methods that extend beyond output tracking (Nevejan et al., 2024^[20]). Russel similarly notes that in community-led contexts, assessment should begin from grassroots priorities rather than institutional assumptions (Russel, 2022^[16]).

Digital platforms such as Decidim, OpenCollective and CitiesDAO further enable participatory monitoring. These tools support transparency, distributed decision making and open data practices. Yet, as Polyák, Bod and Bródy caution, digital systems must be embedded in trust-based relationships and complemented by offline methods to avoid exclusion and institutional drift (Polyák, Bod and Bródy, 2021^[22]). In most cases, hybrid models – combining analogue and digital, formal and informal – are best suited to the civic and adaptive logic of ACS.

To operationalise this approach, the six public value domains introduced in Chapter 1 provide a guiding structure: social cohesion, environmental stewardship and resource efficiency, economic opportunities, cultural expression, temporal adaptability and institutional autonomy. These domains are directly derived from the conceptual building blocks outlined in the theory of change (Table 1.2) and institutional logics of ACS (Table 1.4). They form the basis for a comprehensive evaluation framework (see Table 3.1), linking impact measurement to both systemic outcomes and localised experience.

By grounding evaluation in these domains – and aligning them with OECD well-being frameworks – this approach enables both policymakers and community actors to monitor ACS in ways that are participatory, evidence-based and attuned to real urban conditions. Rather than positioning monitoring as a technical exercise, it becomes a practice of collective learning, legitimacy-building and civic reflection.

Evaluation domains and methods

For a more comprehensive evaluation, it is essential to define specific domains of impact that ACS can contribute to. The following six domains guide the evaluation framework for ACS and are based on insights from interviews and surveys, in which participants were asked to indicate which domains they believe ACS contribute to most directly.

1. **Social cohesion:** ACS can strengthen relationships and trust within communities by supporting spaces for interaction, shared use and collaboration. It facilitates the development at the local level of social networks and collective responsibility (Polyák, Bod and Bródy, 2021^[22]; OECD, 2022^[23]).
2. **Environmental stewardship and resource efficiency:** depending on local conditions and priorities, ACS supports local environmental management and the efficient use of shared spaces and resources, contributing to cost efficiency and risk mitigation through community-led management practices.
3. **Economic opportunities:** ACS can provide platforms for alternative forms of economic activity, including local enterprises, self-employment and co-operative initiatives. By repurposing underused assets and hosting small-scale economic activity, it creates opportunities for income generation and skill development. Embedded in the social and solidarity economy, they support experimentation with circular and community-based models (OECD/European Commission, 2022^[24]). According to the OECD, a social enterprise is “an entity, which trades goods and services, that fulfils a societal objective and whose main purpose is not the maximisation of profit for the owners but its reinvestment for the continued attainment of its societal goals” (OECD, 2022^[8]). Many initiatives operate at the intersection of public value and entrepreneurial practice.
4. **Cultural expression:** ACS functions as cultural infrastructure that supports local identity, memory and creativity. It provides space for artistic production, cultural exchange and the preservation of intangible heritage. Creative hubs within shared urban spaces can contribute to the dynamics of creative cities and local cultural economies (Cohendet, Grandadam and Simon, 2010^[14]).
5. **Temporal adaptability:** ACS responds flexibly to shifting needs through seasonal programming, temporary use and adaptive reuse. Rather than fixed design solutions, it supports evolving spatial configurations over time, reflecting principles of open-ended and adaptive urban development (Partanen, 2023^[25]).
6. **Institutional autonomy:** ACS operates within hybrid governance models that combine local initiative with enabling institutional frameworks. Its capacity to remain flexible and responsive depends on clearly defined roles, shared responsibilities and the ability to balance autonomy with institutional support (Russel, 2022^[16]; Nevejan et al., 2024^[20]).

These six domains help the evaluation process of ACS go beyond traditional metrics, offering a more holistic view of their value. By assessing ACS across these domains, these spaces can be recognised not only for their immediate benefits but also for their long-term contributions to social, cultural, environmental and economic systems.

Table 3.1 builds on the six public value domains and presents a framework for assessing the impact of ACS. Each domain is accompanied by key questions for evaluation, example indicators for measurement and suggested methods for data collection. This framework integrates both conventional and participatory metrics, facilitating a deeper understanding of how ACS contribute to urban resilience, social inclusion and community-driven change.

Table 3.1. Evaluation framework for ACS impact

Domain	Key Questions	Example Indicators	Methods
Social cohesion	How do ACS contribute to building trust and fostering relationships within the community?	Levels of participation in activities, participation in social activities, volunteer involvement	Surveys, interviews, community feedback, social network analysis
Environmental stewardship and resource efficiency	What role does ACS play in environmental management, efficient use of resources and community-led management of shared spaces?	Shared management of space and resources, reuse or efficient use of materials and infrastructure, maintenance practices for shared or green spaces	Environmental audits, surveys on sustainability practices, carbon footprint analysis
Economic opportunities	How do ACS create economic opportunities for local residents and businesses?	Number of local businesses supported, job creation, income generated through ACS-related activities, activation of underused assets or spaces, reduction of entry barriers for local initiatives	Economic surveys, interviews with local businesses, financial tracking of ACS activities
Cultural expression	How do ACS support local cultural expression and creative initiatives?	Number of cultural events held, participation in artistic activities, participation across different types of users in cultural initiatives	Cultural mapping, event tracking, participation surveys, interviews with artists and cultural leaders
Temporal adaptability	How adaptable are ACS in responding to changing community needs over time?	Flexibility in programming, ability to respond to seasonal changes or crises, community feedback on adaptability	Feedback from participants, analysis of programming schedules, longitudinal studies of community needs
Institutional autonomy	What level of institutional support and autonomy does the ACS have and how does this affect its operations?	Degree of shared or delegated decision making, clarity of roles between civic and institutional actors, ability to operate without excessive administrative constraints	Governance surveys, interviews with community leaders and institutional representatives, case studies

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

Participatory monitoring

In addition to defining these impact domains, participatory monitoring and digital tools have a role in ACS evaluation. This involves engaging the community in the evaluation process, allowing them to define what success looks like for their local ACS and to define what intended impact looks like. This approach not only gives voice to those directly involved in and affected by ACS, but also ensures that the metrics reflect the values and priorities of the community. Given that ACS is defined as being shaped by local communities, participatory monitoring can be particularly valuable. Tools like community surveys, participatory observation and narrative reporting can complement conventional metrics, providing richer, context-specific data.

Supporting ACS: Checklist for Public Action

Building on the evaluation framework, this section translates key insights into a strategic governance tool for supporting ACS. As highlighted in this paper, ACS is not a fixed typology but a situated, collectively governed practice that emerges when communities are empowered to co-create and steward shared urban environments. While rooted in local initiative, ACS relies on enabling ecosystems at multiple governance levels, which must provide legitimacy, continuity and protection, while preserving the adaptive nature of civic initiative itself (OECD, 2022^[26]).

This framework encourages governments to move from passive endorsement to proactive actions to enable ACS, recognising community-driven spatial innovation as a core function of urban governance. It builds on the OECD's "Checklist for Public Action", originally developed in the context of decarbonising

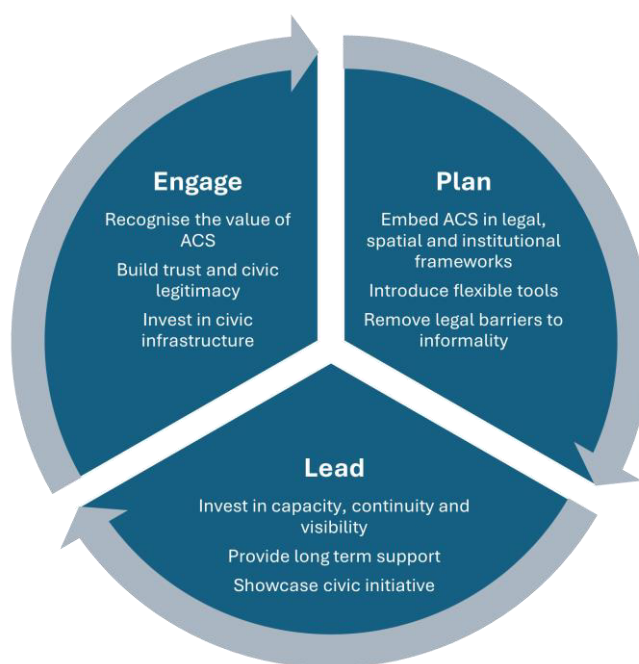
buildings (OECD, 2022^[27]), and adapts its structure and intent to the realm of civic and spatial innovation. The original checklist was designed to guide multi-level governance, regulatory alignment and market engagement in the transition to sustainable building stock. In this paper, it has been adopted and reconfigured to suit the governance needs of ACS. It retains the core phases of “Engage, Plan and Lead”, while adjusting the content to reflect the specific challenges and opportunities of supporting community-led spatial infrastructure.

From tools to trajectory: a strategic approach

The ACS policy framework is not a checklist in the narrow sense of predefined actions. It is a governance trajectory – a strategic learning process that connects civic initiative to institutional support through reflection, alignment and mutual learning. Following the logic of Engage-Plan-Lead, governments at all levels can move beyond ad hoc interventions towards a more integrated approach that recognises ACS as a long-term contributor to resilient cities.

Figure 3.1 visualises the Engage-Plan-Lead framework as an interlinked cycle of public action, not a linear process. It shows how civic initiatives can be aligned with institutional support across three interconnected domains.

Figure 3.1. Public Action Checklist to enable ACS



Note: The figure visualises the Engage-Plan-Lead framework as an interlinked cycle of public action. It illustrates that enabling ACS is not a linear process, but a continuous effort to align civic initiative with institutional support across three mutually reinforcing domains.

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

Engage: Build trust and civic legitimacy

Recognition is the first step. National and regional governments can embed ACS in strategic policy domains – such as well-being, circular economy or civic innovation – to affirm the public value of community-led practices. Doing so can strengthen cross-departmental co-ordination and raise the visibility of ACS as a legitimate part of national agendas.

Local governments can give this recognition through relationships. By investing in civic infrastructure – such as outreach, facilitation and mediation – they can lower participation barriers and support broader engagement in local decisionmaking processes, particularly among residents who are otherwise less likely to engage through formal governance channels (Grueber and Mell, 2022^[28]).

Building trust also requires creating space for autonomy. Authorities should treat ACS not as delivery tools but as partners. Respecting the knowledge, pace and organising principles of civic actors helps build institutional credibility.

Plan: Embed ACS in legal, spatial and institutional frameworks

Although ACS often emerges informally, long-term viability requires some degree of institutional anchoring. National and regional authorities can facilitate this by reforming planning, land use and property laws to accommodate hybrid, adaptive and collectively governed uses of space. Tools such as temporary use clauses, co-operative ownership and flexible zoning can allow civic initiatives to take root without prematurely fixing their form (OECD, 2024^[18]).

Municipalities can operationalise this through updated land-use procedures, simplified permitting regimes and cross-departmental co-ordination. Effective planning for ACS involves different policy fields, such as housing, culture, social or legal affairs. Sustaining institutional openness is essential; rigid frameworks or narrow eligibility criteria may inadvertently exclude the very civic initiatives they aim to support.

In line with (OECD, 2015^[29]) on stakeholder engagement in water governance, cities can better support ACS by explicitly linking them to urban sustainability strategies, for example, by including ACS in green infrastructure planning, climate education programmes or resilience hubs (OECD, 2021^[30]). Planning should not be seen as a linear blueprint, but as an ongoing learning process – one that embraces flexibility, experimentation and adaptive regulation (de Nijs, Majoor and van Wijk, 2022^[31]).

Lead: Invest in capacity, continuity and visibility

Leadership in the ACS context is not about control, but about providing long-term support and guidance, protection, empowerment, and institutional learning. National governments can lead by example: establishing innovation funds, long-term grant schemes and national learning platforms such as ACS observatories or peer exchange networks. This approach aligns with the OECD's *Cities for All Ages* report, which stresses the role of community-based infrastructure in building urban futures for all groups (OECD, 2025^[2]).

Cities can lead through spatial practice. By making land and buildings accessible, supporting shared governance arrangements and embedding ACS principles into broader urban transitions, they show how policy and practice can converge. Governments can amplify the social value of ACS by showcasing exemplary cases, reframing public narratives around shared space and honouring civic initiative.

Leading does not always mean acting. In some cases, creating the conditions for ACS means deliberately holding back. Strategic non-intervention – such as tolerating temporary uses, delaying enforcement or allowing informal experimentation – can offer civic initiatives the space to emerge, evolve and organise. This approach requires trust, timing and political cover, and is especially relevant in contexts where institutional overreach may hinder community initiative. Such calibrated restraint can be a powerful – and often overlooked – form of leadership.

Using the checklist as a tool for dialogue and alignment

The ACS checklist (Table 3.2) is not a prescriptive tool. It is intended as a diagnostic and dialogue instrument – supporting reflection across departments, sectors and levels of government. It helps public actors identify gaps, align responsibilities and mobilise support.

Table 3.2. Linking governance functions to policy levels

Governance Function	National Level	Subnational/Local Level	All Levels of Government
Engage	Embed ACS in national strategies for well-being, civic innovation and circular economy. Align ministerial policies across departments (urban, culture, environment, social). Recognise ACS as generators of public value.	Invest in civic infrastructure (facilitation, mediation, outreach). Build trust through respect for local tempo, culture and organising principles (Grueber and Mell, 2022^[28]). Support capacity-building in under-resourced communities.	Enable intergovernmental dialogue on ACS. Foster peer learning between cities and regions. Create shared platforms for policy experimentation and civic co-creation.
Plan	Reform land-use and planning law to include adaptive, hybrid uses. Introduce flexible tools (temporary use clauses, co-operative tenure, adaptive zoning). Remove legal barriers to informality.	Integrate ACS into urban plans and spatial visions. Simplify permitting and create pathways from informal to formal recognition. Promote cross-departmental co-ordination (planning, culture, social policy, legal affairs). Allow for iterative planning and experimentation (de Nijs, Majoor and van Wijk, 2022^[31]).	Align strategic frameworks and funding channels. Co-ordinate between local innovation and national scaling. Support monitoring frameworks that allow comparison and mutual learning.
Lead	Establish long-term grant schemes and ACS innovation funds. Launch national platforms for learning and policy transfer (e.g. observatories, exchanges). Protect civic space through institutional safeguards.	Provide access to land, buildings and legal advice. Support shared governance structures and long-term stewardship. Honour civic initiative as part of social infrastructure (Klinenberg, 2018^[11]).	Communicate the public value of ACS. Showcase exemplary projects through awards and campaigns. Promote new narratives of space as commons and citizens as co-creators.

Source: Author's elaboration derived from expert interviews, user surveys and a comparative literature review.

Conclusion: Enabling ACS as civic infrastructure, from recognition to institutionalisation

Adaptive communal space (ACS) demonstrates a clear capacity to generate public value across multiple domains – from social cohesion and environmental stewardship to economic development and democratic innovation. This potential becomes most tangible where public institutions provide enabling frameworks that are flexible, inclusive and responsive. As shown in this paper – through conceptual models, empirical case studies and evaluation approaches – ACS does not succeed by exception, but by intentionally integrating it into an ongoing development. In diverse contexts, community-led spaces thrive when civic initiative is recognised as legitimate, institutionally supported and aligned with broader urban strategies.

Yet, the true significance of ACS lies not only in the outcomes it produces, but in the processes through which it takes shape. These processes – grounded in negotiation, iterative emergence and shared authorship – are what distinguish ACS from more conventional forms of placemaking or short time activation programmes. They signal a deeper shift in the relationship between people, space and institutions – one that prioritises agency, care and collaboration over control, efficiency or formal status.

To support this shift, public actors need to move beyond symbolic recognition and toward long-term, structural commitment. ACS should not be treated as marginal, transitional or exceptional. It constitutes a

vital layer of civic infrastructure, one that enables cities to become more adaptive and grounded in civic participation.

Translating this understanding into practice calls for concrete and co-ordinated action across different domains of governance. The following strategic priorities distil the core lessons of this paper into actionable guidance for policymakers and institutions. Their aim is not to prescribe fixed solutions, but to foster conditions under which ACS can continue to evolve, adapt and contribute to resilient urban futures.

- **Support while preserving civic autonomy.** ACS thrive when local communities maintain their self-organised character. Public support is essential, but it should amplify, not absorb, the civic initiative at the heart of these spaces. This means avoiding over-formalisation, enabling experimentation and recognising informal or hybrid forms of governance as legitimate contributors to public value.
- **Invest in governance capacity.** The sustainability of ACS depends on more than access to space; it requires time, relationships, facilitation and adaptive co-ordination. Governments can treat these capacities as core urban infrastructure, providing structural funding, mentorship and tools that enable communities to govern collectively over time.
- **Safeguard civic access to space and procedures.** Community-led initiatives need reliable access to land, buildings and legal pathways. This calls for adaptable instruments that accommodate collective use such as temporary use agreements, flexible leases or zoning exemptions. It is equally important that permitting and regulatory processes are transparent and accessible to grassroots actors.
- **Promote institutional co-ordination.** ACS initiatives rarely fit neatly within existing bureaucratic silos. Effective support requires horizontal co-ordination across departments (e.g. culture, planning, social affairs) and vertical collaboration between civic actors and institutions. Cities can develop mechanisms that foster learning and responsiveness across sectors and spatial scales.
- **Reframe evaluation practice.** The impact of ACS is often relational, incremental and context-specific. Policymakers can move beyond purely quantitative metrics and adopt participatory evaluation frameworks that include community-defined indicators. This strengthens accountability while reinforcing trust and shared ownership.
- **Democratise experimentation.** ACS must be allowed to grow, shift and adapt. Governments can protect the space for collective learning and civic innovation through pilot programmes, iterative governance arrangements and support for initiatives at different stages of development. Formalisation should be a choice, not a condition.

In conclusion, supporting ACS is not only about securing physical space, but about recognising the broader civic, spatial and institutional conditions that allow such spaces to emerge and endure. As Foucault highlighted, space is never neutral – it is shaped by power, governance and social practice. Contextualising ACS within its specific urban and social environment ensures that these initiatives remain adaptable and responsive to local needs (Foucault, 1977^[12]). Ultimately, the challenge is not merely to create space for ACS, but to foster an urban ecosystem in which communities are enabled to adapt, innovate and co-create the resilient cities of the future.

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